

Sanjay Gupta's Professional Innings

1996-1997: Design Engineer at Duet Technologies

June 2003-August 2005: Design Manager, India Design Centre, Freescale Semiconductor

August 2005 to April 2016: Senior Director of Engineering, Automotive & Industrial MCU, India Design Centre, Freescale Semiconductor

April 2016 to November 2022: VP & India Country Manager, NXP Semiconductors

November 2022-Present: President & CEO, Spark Minda, Minda Corporation

the engineering entrance exam on the first attempt, but the rank he secured couldn't get him a seat in electronics engineering! His father sensed Gupta was not happy and gave him the courage to take a year off and prepare better.

The following year, in the Delhi Engineering Entrance Exams, he secured a rank among the top 150 students, ensuring him entrance to electronics and communications engineering at the prestigious Delhi College Of Engineering. "That wasn't what I initially wanted, but my father said it's all for the better, and I accepted it," he explains. And thus began his journey into the world of semiconductors, a word that most of India loves today!

₹750 to \$70,000

Suji Ka Halwa was what the Guptas made to celebrate Sanjay's first day at DCE. The entire Gupta family was fond of Indian sweets. Sanjay Gupta remembers walking behind his father on his journey from the bus to the college's auditorium on that first day. Despite having visited the college a week before the academic session began, he confesses that he still had butterflies in his stomach on the first day.

"Me and one of my friends decided to visit our college a week prior to starting the academic session. The moment we entered, seniors living in the hostel caught hold of us and took us to the hostel. We were made to give introductions, clean utensils, and rooms of seniors.

We were probably the first ones to undergo ragging even before joining the college," he shares one of the many incidents from his college life.

By this time, Gupta was accustomed to speaking good English, making new friends irrespective of their background, and had a lot of self-confidence. He credits his days of IIT preparation for these skills. The friends he made at college encouraged him to participate in a singing competition. He still sings, but he admits that his performance during the competition at DCE was a result of his friends praising him to the skies.

"I do not think anyone was impressed by my singing that day," he laughs, as if he is present in the college auditorium, listening to the famous speech by Chatur Ramalingam from '3 Idiots.' However, one of these friends and seniors laid the foundation for what he is today. This senior recommended him a book titled 'Advanced Microelectronics.' To Gupta, this book remains the Bible for learning anything and everything about SoC design and semiconductors.

At that time (1993-1994), this book was not readily available in India. Most of the students who had it had it delivered from countries like the United States. Its cost was over ₹750, and to Gupta it seemed like a luxury. He wasn't sure if the book would fit in the Gupta family's budget with their overall expenses. "I went to my father and said I want this book because I want to master

the field of semiconductors. My father said nothing at that moment," he remembers.

When his father returned home the next day, he placed the book in Gupta's hands and said, "*Ja master ban ja semiconductors ka*" (Go and become the master of semiconductors). He searched all over Delhi, contacted everyone he knew to make sure his son didn't have to wait for that book. He assured him not to worry about the finances and to concentrate on his studies.

And how critical was that book for Gupta?

He answers, "The first interview I cracked was because of that book." An Indian startup headed by Prabhu Goyal was visiting the college during the on-campus recruitment drive, and Gupta was selected to work for this startup's office in the United States. Named Duet Technologies, this startup was later acquired by Motorola.

"From that ₹750 that my father went out of his way to spend, I landed a job in the United States that was paying me close to \$60,000 then. On my first day at the office, I was given a Honda Accord to drive. Though I didn't know how to drive back then, I learned it from a Chinese instructor in America," he adds. He took the written test for a driver's license in California after just one day of preparation.

He laughs and says, "We Indians probably have a knack for clearing written entrance exams."

Do not increase my salary

As Gupta was learning the ropes of the semiconductor game in the United States, his father suffered a heart attack. "That night (daytime in India), I woke up in the middle of the night. I don't know why, but something in me, or something I didn't know, kept telling me